

Hearts and flowers depicted in the bride's cake centerpiece



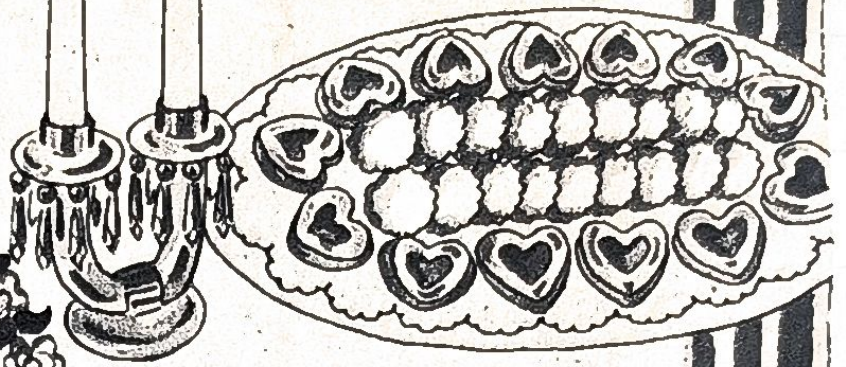
or marmalade; and cookies or cake as dessert. Hot breads, by the way, are served only at casual, intimate teas—never at larger, more formal entertainments.

THE SEMIFORMAL TEA

The afternoon tea approaches formal proportions when the guest list numbers 10 or more and when the tea is served in the dining room and is poured not by the hostess but, preferably, by a close friend. There need not be any reason for the tea other than the desire to make a gesture of friendliness. However, it is a grand way to honor an out-of-town friend or a newcomer to the town or neighborhood, to announce an engagement, or to pay off an accumulation of social obligations.

The invitations, which should go out three weeks ahead of time, may take the form of friendly notes, particularly if the guests are close friends. The more formal way of bidding the guests is to write the invitations on visiting cards in the following manner:

To meet Mrs. John Doe
 Mrs. Henry Smith
 Friday
 June Twentieth
 Tea at four o'clock
 16 Bush Avenue



The semiformal tea is, of course, far more ceremonious than the intimate tea. One or more friends, appointed by the hostess, answer the door and show the guests to a room where they remove their coats. (It is usually considered better form for the guests to keep their hats on during the tea. However, in many communities hats are removed, according to the custom of the neighborhood.) Then the guests are shown into the living room, where the hostess and guests of honor, if there are any, are receiving.

Unless it is expressly understood that long dresses are to be worn, street or afternoon clothes are appropriate. The hostess, guest of honor, and helpers, however, may wear long dresses. The hostess, of course, usually wears the same type of clothes as the honored guest.

The tea and food are served in the dining room unless the party is held out of doors. The table is covered with the best linen or lace the hostess owns (or can borrow), and the food is assembled in buffet fashion on one or both sides of the table, depending on whether the table is set against the wall or in the center of the room.

Flowers usually occupy the center of the table. However, the centerpiece may be of attractively arranged leaves, fruits, gourds, or vegetables if they are in keeping with the other table appointments. Illustrated is an effective center arrangement which we worked out for one of our teas, using ivy leaves. If the shades are drawn or the day is dark, candles may be lighted and placed on each side of the centerpiece. Candles are never used unlighted or in broad daylight.

The tea service is arranged on a



tray at one end of the table. Seated and pouring the tea is a friend of the hostess—usually chosen because she knows most of the guests. At the other end of the table may be a coffee or chocolate service on a tray, presided over by another friend.

The food is always light so that it will not dull the appetite, and usually there are several teatime dainties to choose from. Sandwiches, small cakes, thin slices of cake or cookies, and salted nuts or mints may be arranged on the table, as we've illustrated. Saucers are seldom used. The teacup is set on a small plate, and after it is given to the guest, she helps herself from the array of dishes.

As the hostess should be free to mix with her guests, she usually appoints some of her younger friends to take the empty cups

from the guests, to keep the tea and coffee or chocolate pots filled, and to replenish the serving plates.

At a semiformal tea the guests seldom remain over an hour, and they may take their leave in a half hour. At very large teas some of the guests may be invited for the first hour and some for the second hour. In this way a larger number may be entertained without fear of overcrowding the house.

THE RECEPTION

Much has been written in etiquette books about the formal receptions which precede or follow some important event or an elaborate wedding. Little has been said, however, on the subject of the simpler home receptions that follow either large or small church or home weddings. And judging from the many letters received from our readers, it is the simpler type of reception that is more popular.

All the wedding guests or just a small number of the closer friends and acquaintances may be invited to the reception. Or a large reception may follow a wedding that has been attended only by relatives and close friends.

It is considered best form to enclose a separate engraved reception invitation with the wedding invitation or announcement. However, if the reception is small, the invitations may be extended orally. The wedding invitations and invitations to the reception are sent out about two weeks before the marriage is to take place. And it is a courtesy to acknowledge them by sending the acceptance or regrets within a week. The same holds true with the sending of wedding gifts. In consideration of the guests the reception should be held immediately after the wedding ceremony.

Authorities do not agree on who is in the receiving line at a reception. Of course, the bride and bridegroom and the bride's attendants are always waiting to receive the guests as they arrive. The parents of the bride and bridegroom may also be in the line or they may be free to mingle with the guests. The same holds true for the ushers.

Formal tea table with trailing ivy for the centerpiece

